substantial investments from Salem and Erode. Directors from Salem claimed to have taken shares worth Rs 1 lakh.[66] Then a successful lawyer from Salem, C. Rajagopalachari (Rajaji), according to his grandson-biographer contributed Rs 1,000 to the shipping company despite his father's disapproval.[67] (Many years later, Rajaji clarified that he had contributed *after* the company fell on hard times and not in its early upbeat days.[68]) While contemporary reports said that Rs 25,000 was collected in Erode,[69] Periyar E.V. Ramasamy, who was a prominent trader in the town at that time, gives a figure of Rs 35,000—Rs 5,000 from his own sources, another 5,000 from Muslim traders and the rest collected in multiples of Rs 500 from here and there.[70]

About 3,000 shares were subscribed to in Colombo and it is likely that the subscribers drew mainly from the many Tamil merchants based there.[71]

Canvassing for Shares

As a political project, SSNCo was oriented towards raising capital from the public rather than limit itself to big traders and successful lawyers. VOC was casting a wide net. In his initial prospectus, VOC expressly stated that the share value had been kept low to attract the common people.[72]

While SSNCo itself circulated share applications forms along with prospectus, many newspapers carried the full text of the prospectus with pro forma of the share application form over many issues.[73]

Investment in a new company, despite the Swadeshi hype, could not by itself draw adequate capital. Sustained efforts were required. Swadeshi personalities as well as volunteers and paid employees fanned out into the presidency and outside to canvass for shares.

VOC's Tours

VOC himself led from the front.

He began first with the merchants of Tuticorin. There is a badly damaged letter that has survived from the time when the ink on the company's